One evening at Affies three years earlier, when we were both prefects keeping watch over Standard 6 boys while they were supposed to be studying, Derick and I sat down, set some targets for ourselves and wrote them in a little book: one was to play for an Affies team that won the Beeld Trophy, which we did (although we predicted we would play Middelburg in the final and we actually played Waterkloof), and another was that we would one day play for South Africa in rugby or cricket; it didn't matter which.

That night we made a pact that, if either of us ever did play for South Africa at either sport, the other would make sure he was there, in the stands, watching the debut.

Derick proved as good as his word and took his place at St George's Park alongside my parents. I am just sad that, though he had a fantastic rugby career, captaining the Bulls at every level, playing more than 100 provincial matches, captaining South African schools, playing for the South African Under-19, Under-21 and Sevens teams, he was never given the chance to play for the Springboks. If he had, I would have been sitting there in the stands.

My first Test was a blur …

It's a hot day in Port Elizabeth and the warm-up feels especially tough. Ray is cracking the whip as usual, and I am enjoying the intensity, working hard. My shirt is drenched. Captain Graeme Smith wins the toss and we will open our innings together. I am still sweating from the warm-up.

Matthew Hoggard bowls the first over. Second ball of the match, Graeme fends outside off stump, finds the edge and Andrew Strauss takes a decent catch at third slip. We are zero for one and Jacques Rudolph comes out to join me in the middle, two old Affies side by side under pressure. Steve Harmison, then ranked as the No. 1 bowler in the world, bowls the second over. I am focused on surviving.

In the ninth over, Harmison offers some width outside off stump and